Leiden University Library

Abstract

Leiden University Library (UBL) houses a wide range of material relevant to conducting research on collections from a colonial context. In addition to books, journals and manuscripts, the UBL houses extensive archival collections and photographic material.

History of the organisation

The Polyglot Bible was a gift from Willem of Orange to the University of Leiden on the occasion of its foundation in 1575 and marked the symbolic establishment of the university library. The library was officially opened in 1587 and was located in what is now Leiden University's academy building on Rapenburg. Since the publication of the first library catalogue, the Nomenclator, in 1595, the collection has grown to include many millions of books, manuscripts and other types of documents. Since 2009 the various libraries that had been established at Leiden University over the years have been merged under the name Leiden University Libraries (UBL). The UBL consists of the general university library and the libraries for Social Sciences, Law, Mathematics & Natural Sciences and the East Asian Library.

With regard to research into colonial histories, the UBL manages a large relevant collection, particularly since taking over the collections of the Koninlijk Instituut voor de Tropen (Royal Tropical Institute) and the Royal Netherlands Institute of Southeast Asian and Caribbean Studies (KITLV) in 2013 and 2014, respectively. The library of the Netherlands Institute for the Near East was incorporated into the UBL in 2018.

In addition to its collection of written sources, the UBL manages a large number of special collections, some of which are also digitally available. The subject guides provide more information about the wide range of available sources and where to find them. Besides conventional books, the collection contains tens of thousands of manuscripts, maps, cuneiform tablets and miniatures.

Research

The UBL's digital catalogue can be consulted online and contains books, periodicals and other types of material. Various subject guides are available to facilitate your search. The digitised special collections can also be consulted online. In addition to its extensive collection, the UBL manages a large amount of archive material, both from Leiden University itself and from personal and other archives. Detailed descriptions of the various archive collections can be found in the collection guides, which contain extensive information about the available material. If you are unable to find certain information, you can always contact the organisation.

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Related Aids

- Sources
- Scientific research in colonised territories
- Royal Netherlands Institute of Southeast Asian and Caribbean Studies (KITLV)
- University collections

Primary sources

Secondary sources

Website:

> *Online catalogue of the Leiden University Library The online catalogue of Leiden University Libraries allows you to browse the entire library catalogue. Books, journals, other documents and archive material can be requested for reference through this website. You will need a Leiden University user card for this.*
>
> https://catalogue.leidenuniv.nl/discovery/search?vid=31UKB_LEU:UBL_V1

Website:

> *Subject guides Guides by subject that can help you find relevant material for your research.*
>
> https://www.library.universiteitleiden.nl/subject-guides

Website:

> *Collection guides This website provides access to the collection guides of the archives and collections of Leiden University Libraries. Collection guides provide a general description of the items within a collection or archive and provide information about the history and acquisition of the material. The collection guides on this website may also contain an inventory and links to digitised content.*
>
> https://collectionguides.universiteitleiden.nl/

Relevant Data

TO BE FILLED

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